



Bare Bones Basics: Couponing 101

Remember my mistakes in the shopping game? Falling for the “blue light special” in Kmart and buying things I didn’t need just because they are “on sale.” This is one of the common mistakes made among consumers. I still make those kinds of mistakes, just not at a Kmart or with a blue light special. Having signed up for every deal site on the Internet has resulted in my inbox being inundated with daily offers. I have to be constantly vigilant. Just because Groupon offers me seventy dollars in stationery products for seventeen dollars, or Ebates doubles a store’s cash back for a single day, doesn’t mean I have to take advantage of those offers. I always have to ask myself if it was a purchase I would be making otherwise? Or would I just be spending money to take advantage of a perceived “good deal?”

This should have been the easiest chapter to write. For thirty-three years I’ve used coupons. I write a weekly newspaper column on couponing and present couponing workshops for community colleges and women’s groups. I’ve even mentored a sister who began using coupons during the year I was writing this book. And yet, I dug in my heels and resisted writing this chapter—the how-to of the hobby. Why?

For one thing, there are entire books, websites, and seminars that can teach someone how to get started in couponing. My couponing workshops